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From Objective Character Motivation to Learners' Subjective Reconstruction

A Pilot Study on Conceptual Mapping in the Rén Component Family among Spanish-Speaking Learners of Chinese

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Is the Rén component family visually transparent, or cognitively reconstructible?

The Rén component family is historically motivated by the graphic representation of the human figure, but this motivation is not necessarily perceived directly by Spanish-speaking learners.

Research problem

Objective character motivation ≠ learner interpretation

Historical accounts explain the Rén component family through character structure, etymology, and form–meaning relations. However, learner responses show that this objective motivation does not automatically become learner-perceived motivation.

The issue is not only what these characters historically represent, but how Spanish-speaking learners interpret them, extract visual cues, activate associations, and construct subjective rationales from graphic form.

Pilot study

- **Participants:** 9 Spanish-speaking learners of Chinese
- **Learning background:** approximately 4 months
- **Task:** open-ended interpretation and association of character forms
- **Focus:** the character 人 rén and its component family
- **Data:** exploratory questionnaire responses
- **Analysis:** inductive coding of learner responses

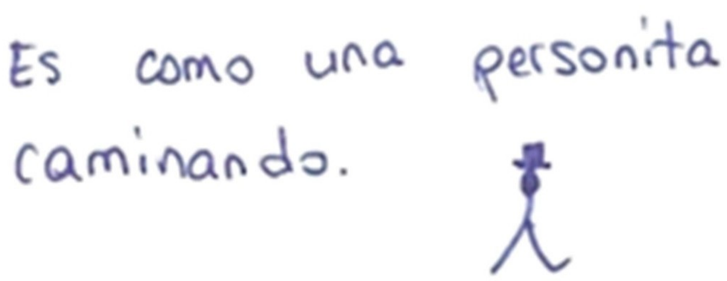
Results: learner interpretations across the Rén component family

象形 Pictographs

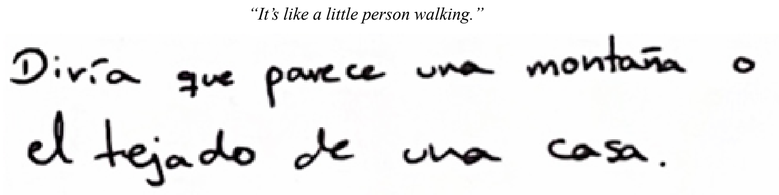
人

Perceptual level: the human figure is not fully transparent.
Explanatory level: learners may construct interpretations that approach the traditional pictographic rationale.

Examples: "Es como una personita caminando" vs. "una montaña / el tejado de una casa".



"Es como una personita caminando."
"It's like a little person walking."



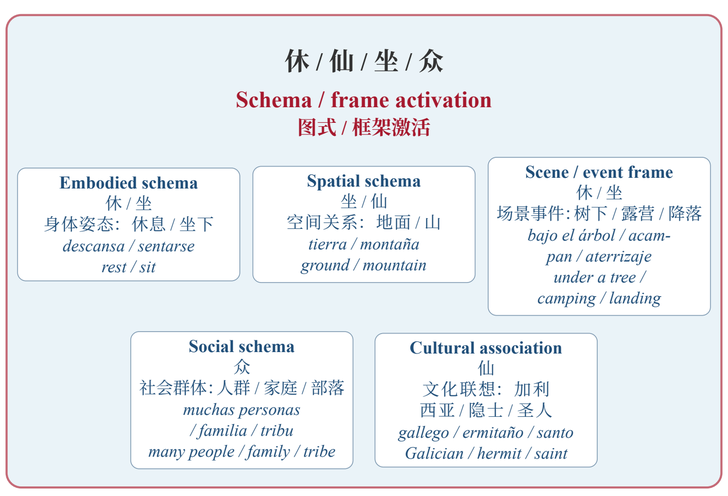
"Diría que parece una montaña o el tejado de una casa."
"I would say it looks like a mountain or the roof of a house."

会意 Associative compounds

休 / 仙 / 坐 / 众

In associative compounds, learners interpret the whole character through configurations of person-related components with other graphic elements. These configurations act as triggers for embodied, spatial, social, and contextual schemas, which learners integrate into subjective rationales.

Key pattern: component configurations activate multiple schemas and frames that learners integrate into subjective rationales.



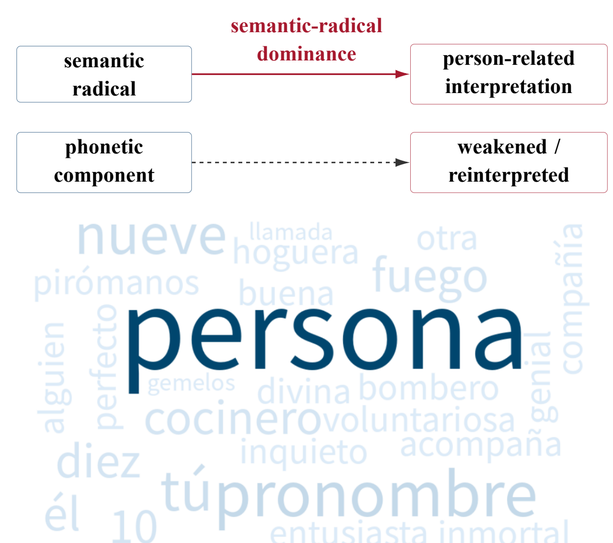
Selected responses show how component configurations activate multiple schemas and frames.

形声 Phono-semantic compounds

你 / 什 / 伙

In phono-semantic characters with 亻, learners tended to privilege the person-related semantic component, while the phonetic component was weakened, ignored, or semantically reinterpreted.

Key pattern: learners interpret phono-semantic characters through semantic-radical dominance rather than full phono-semantic decomposition.



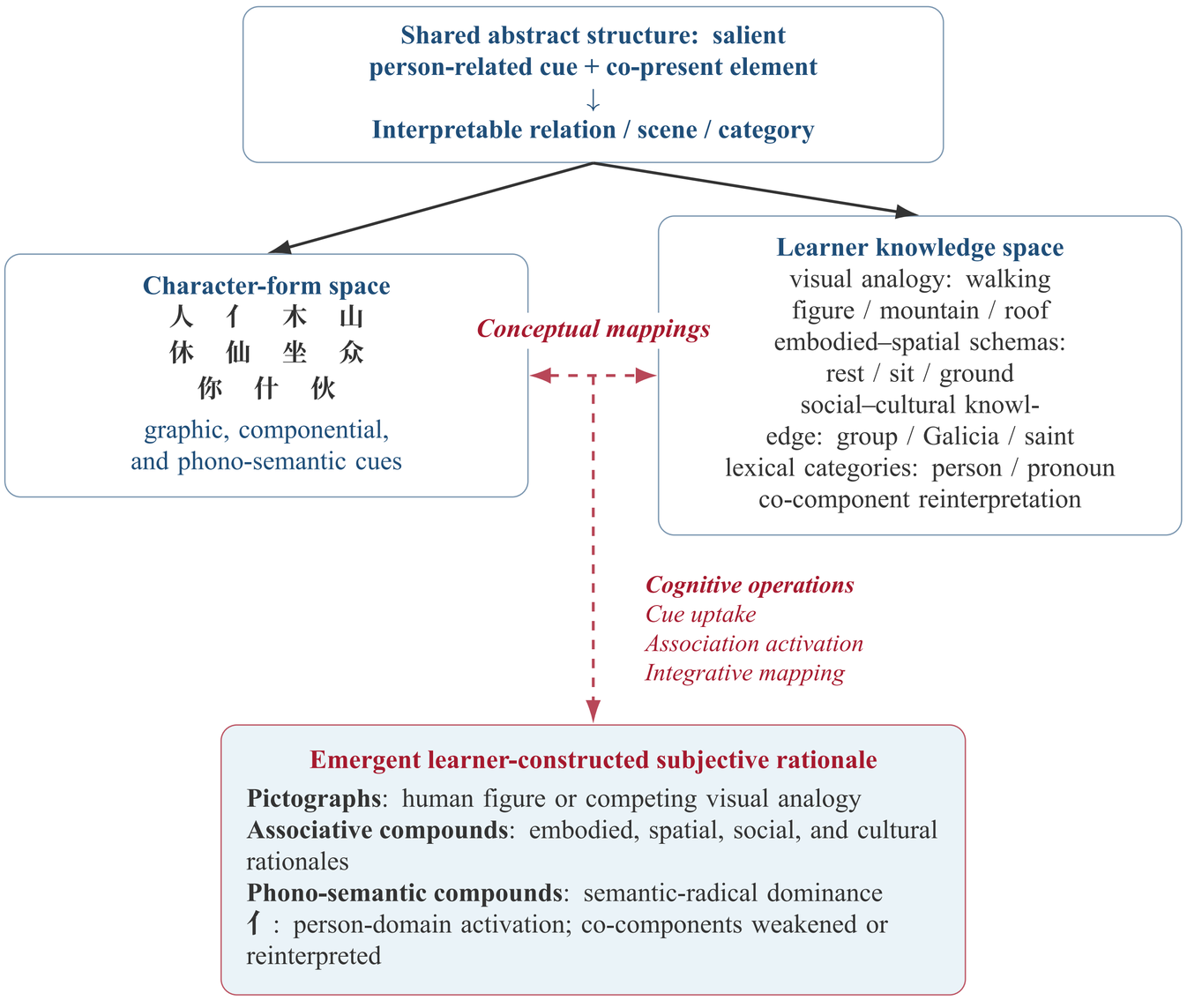
Learner responses to characters with 亻 (*persona*) emerges as the dominant association.

Objective character motivation ≠ Learner interpretation

From observed response patterns to a reconstruction model

Learners use graphic and semantic cues from the whole character or its components as triggers to activate associations and construct subjective rationales.

Conceptual mapping model



Selected elements from character-form and learner knowledge spaces are projected into a blended space, where subjective rationales emerge.

Mechanism, implications and supplement

Mechanism

1. Non-automatic transparency
Objective character motivation does not automatically become learner-perceived motivation.

2. Cue-triggered reconstruction
Learners use whole-character forms, component configurations, and salient radicals as triggers for interpretation.

3. Selective integration
Learners integrate selected graphic cues with embodied, spatial, social, and cultural schemas.

Teaching implications

Do not treat etymology as self-evident.
Subjective rationales can serve as a bridge toward more systematic character-structure explanation.

Use learner rationales as scaffolding.
Learner associations reveal how graphic form is processed and connected with meaning.

Guide from association to structure.
Teaching can start from learner rationales while setting boundaries against arbitrary interpretation.

Deviations are outcomes of cognitive strategy selection.

Pedagogy should attend to subjective rationale construction alongside character-structure explanation.

References

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Scan for poster PDF, references, and contact.

Keywords: Chinese character orthography; Rén component; conceptual mapping; learner reconstruction; Spanish-speaking learners; Chinese character teaching